The Pakistanis had heard about me, but only because I had defeated their hero two years ago in Tokyo. They felt that the time had come for Khaliq to avenge his defeat. While the two of us were going through our warm-up exercises, there were deafening shouts from all the spectators: ‘Long Live Pakistan, Long Live Abdul Khaliq.’ The entire audience kept cheering for him as he walked in before me, followed by other Pakistani athletes and Makhan Singh, the only other Indian besides me.

At the starting line, I put down my bag, warmed-up and wiped the perspiration from my body with a towel. As we waited for the race to begin, a couple of moulvis, with flowing beards, skullcaps and carrying rosaries in their hands, encircled Khaliq. They blessed him, saying, ‘May Allah be with you.’ Irritated by this blatant favouritism, I shouted, ‘Moulvi Sahib, we, too, are the children of the same God. Don’t we deserve the same blessings?’ For a moment, they were dumbstruck, and then one of them half-heartedly muttered, ‘May God strengthen your legs, too.’

There was pin-drop silence as we stood at the starting line waiting for the race to begin. The silence was oppressive. The starter, dressed in a white shirt and trousers, a red overall, white peaked cap and black shoes, stood on a table behind us. He shouted, ‘On your marks,’ fired the gun and the race began. The audience suddenly awoke and began to chant: ‘Pakistan zindabad; Abdul Khaliq zindabad.’ Khaliq was ahead of me but I caught up before we had completed the first 100 metres. We were shoulder-to-shoulder, then surprisingly, Khaliq seemed to slacken and I surged ahead as if on wings. I finished the 200 metres about ten yards ahead of Khaliq, clocking 20.7 seconds that equalled the world record. My coach, Ranbir Singh, the manager and all my team members leapt to their feet in jubilation. I was embraced, thumped on the back and then lifted on to their shoulders as they expressed their happiness both vocally and physically.

It was indeed a joyful day for India, but a terrible tragedy for Pakistan. Khaliq himself was so devastated that he lay on the ground weeping pitifully. I patted his back and tried to console him by saying that victory and defeat were part of the same game and should not be taken to heart, but he was too humiliated by the fact that he had been defeated before the eyes of his countrymen.

After the race, I ran a victory lap of the stadium, while loudspeakers announced: ‘The athlete running before you is Milkha Singh. He does not run, he flies! His victory will be recorded in Pakistan’s sports’ history, and